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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

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Place Coverage: G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana

Section Title(S): Divorce • Polygamy

Co-wives occupy separate but adjacent huts or shelters. Although each gathers and prepares food for her own children and for herself, the co-wives usually travel together when out gathering and assist each other in lifting and carrying loads. They also help one another in hut building and other domestic tasks, including the care of one another's children, to whom tidbits, but not regular meals, are fed.

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Implicit in polygynous households is the problem of sexual relations. A woman must not conceive until she has weaned her youngest child, normally when the child is 3 or 4 years old. Informants were unanimous that abstinence is the only means of contraception and that this was a grueling test of a husband's willpower, as the responsibility for avoiding conception was his. I did not inquire into the stresses that might be imposed on a polygynous household by the sexual accessibility of only one of the co-wives, nor why the greater opportunity for intercourse did not enhance the rather low popularity of polygyny as a form of marriage. These were rather delicate topics.

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Divorce

I have already mentioned that the marriage of a young, childless couple may be ended without formality. All marriages may be dissolved by unilateral decision of either spouse or by mutual consent. The only semblance of formality is the act of either partner's leaving the conjugal hut and taking up residence elsewhere after having declared his or her intention not to return. Incompatibility of temperament and flagrant adultery are the recognized causes of marital breakup. Incompatibility is revealed by frequent arguments between the couple and accusations of laziness, stinginess, and *xamxasi* (literally, lion-like, i.e., brutality, violence, and excessively short temper), which characteristics are regarded as serious character defects by the G/wi. Any threat to marriage is a matter of interest to the band. Apart from the excitement that the drama of domestic strife may lend, there is genuine concern that conflict not develop too far. Friends and close kin readily intercede to avoid a breakup. An adulterous spouse is quietly told by friends to mend his or her ways, or if it can be done without precipitating marital disaster, the offending husband or wife is publicly teased by his or her joking partners. Demeanor  157 is the important factor; even where the inference of adultery is inescapable (e.g., when a wife returns 4 months' pregnant after a 6-month visit to another band), no objection is raised by the husband or anybody else. Should, however, the adulterous genitor lay claim to the child when it is born, or should he or the wife boast of the liaison, a fight and possibly divorce will follow. Even where liaisons were open secrets in the band, they were tolerated if no overt indications were given that would force the husband or wife to take public cognizance of the partner's infidelity.

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